

Both shared the dressing room for Delhi and the North Zone and scored centuries on their Test debuts. Their sharp hand-eye coordination matched their instinct to be aggressive when the situation called for it.

Dhawan owed it to his coaches for correcting his form and style at the right time. He was not a side-on batsman. His prudence helped him respect Prabhakar's suggestion to close his stance, which worked wonders. Dhawan got the balance right, which was sufficient to turn the keen eyes of the selectors towards his

game and his promise to deliver high-class batting for his country.

Known to be resilient under pressure and someone who never shied away from a good challenge, Dhawan loved to field at short leg. In this position, the fielder must quickly react to catch the batter off-guard. This position makes one vulnerable to injuries, so newcomers are usually coaxed into fielding there.

But Dhawan had his intentions. Perched right next to the batters, he could quickly resort to a light sprinkle of hazing to break their concentration.

Dhawan was conferred the moniker *Gabbar* since he used to repeat the dialogues of the famous movie character in the Bollywood film *Sholay* within the batter's earshot. A lip injury prevented him from shaving, giving him the excuse to grow his moustache. Once his fans started emulating the same fashion, he had all the reason to brandish it and make it part of his persona. The slap on the thigh was a typical Dhawan expression to celebrate.

Known for his upbeat attitude throughout the cricket circle, Dhawan greeted you with a firm handshake, welcomed you home with a warm smile, and even spotted a dear friend from afar in a bustling crowd to rush and hug them tight. In the words of Ashish Nehra, "We call him *Shikhar befiqar*."

Bowing out: Shikhar Dhawan captained India in 15 games (12 ODIs and 3 T20Is). The left-hand opener scored 24 hundreds across 269 matches for India. AFP

